Introduction.

Analysing National Liberation Movements as Governments

The struggle for liberation in southern Africa was a cause célèbre for most of the second half of the 20th century. The colonizing powers vacated the major portion of Sub-Saharan Africa, with varying degrees of grace, during the three decades following the end of the Second World War – yet the 1960s saw only the beginning of what the activist-scholar John Saul has come to term, with an ironic nod to European history, the 'thirty years war' for national liberation in the Portuguese-ruled territories of Angola and Mozambique, settler-ruled Rhodesia, and apartheid South Africa. The sacrifices incurred in the different yet closely related and inter-dependent struggles for independence are remarkable. Indeed, they probably remain underestimated by the majority of historians today. Nonetheless, the long-drawn-out process of liberation – in so far as this refers to crude racial domination – was eventually to become complete: the Portuguese beat a hasty retreat from Angola and Mozambique in 1975 following a coup (prompted by the strains imposed by running a costly and brutal war) the previous year; the settler regime in Rhodesia, after having declared unilateral independence from Britain in 1965, had to concede majority rule to 'Zimbabwe' in 1980, following, notably, a crucial withdrawal of support by neighbouring South Africa in the late 1970s; South West Africa, the United Nations' Trust Territory which had been under *de facto* South African rule since 1916 was transformed into independent Namibia in 1989 following extensive international pressure; and South Africa itself made its widely celebrated move to democracy in 1994, after an intense, troubled, compelling but ultimately inspiring period of political transition.

In so far as these liberation struggles ended in defeat for racial minority rule and victory for the principle of democracy, an historic triumph was won. Yet looking back, from the early 21st century it is a widely held view that 'national liberation movements as governments' have proved to be a disappointment not only to their many sympathizers internationally but above all, to the majority of people over whom they now rule. Whereas at one time liberation movements represented 'the answer' to southern Africa's woes, they are now increasingly seen as 'the problem'. This book sets out to examine what that 'problem' is, where its origins lie, and suggests in what direction we should look for a new set of 'answers'. It will do so by analysing the diverse experiences of Namibia, South Africa and Zimbabwe, the focus being upon their hegemonic liberation movements – the South West African People's Organization (SWAPO), the African National Congress (ANC), and the Zimbabwe African National Union-Patriotic Front (ZANU-PF) – as governments. The purpose of the exercise will be to explore both the implications of 'liberation movement' status for the character of their governance after the transition to democracy, and how their individual histories and legacies shape the nature and quality of their rule.

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Liberation movements and African nationalism

'National liberation movements' (NLMs) belong to the generic set of anti-colonial movements which developed in reaction to colonialism. However, those African nationalist movements which earned the sobriquet of 'NLMs' and identified themselves as such did so in particular circumstances. In most of Sub-Saharan Africa, colonial rulers 'withdrew' as much as they were 'pushed', for calculating that the costs of hanging on to power were becoming greater than the advantages of staying. As 'dependency' theory emphasizes, the nature of the historical experience of colonialism was such that it tended to structure the political economies of colonies so that they remained heavily 'dependent' upon their former colonial powers even after they had handed over political management to successor nationalist governments. Nonetheless, in some countries and regions, notably in those where sizeable minorities of white 'settlers' had made Africa their home, African nationalist movements were confronted by a refusal of incumbent regimes to concede power. Of course, the roots of African nationalism go deep into colonial history, planted in the soil of original African resistance to the very imposition of colonialism, and subsequently moving through formative stages of respectful lobbying for rights before, generally, flowering into a phase – or phases – of mass protest and action. In the large majority of countries in Sub-Saharan Africa, post-Second World War colonial calculations of the costs of long-term repression of such resistance led to a reasonably dignified withdrawal. Yet in settler territories, where nationalist movements met concerted resistance, they found themselves having to resort to armed struggle – from Algeria in the far north, through Kenya in the east, down to the countries in the south.

Armed struggle required the transformation of nationalist movements into what have become widely known as NLMs, (unless, as in Kenya, armed struggle was militarily defeated by the colonial power preparatory to its making political concessions to a more conservative nationalism). Belonging to the same anti-colonial family, nationalist movements and NLMs share many traits. Up to a certain point, they had tended to follow a similar trajectory. Indeed, southern African nationalist movements had widely assumed that their various lobbying and mass mobilizations of protest would, as in other African territories, lead ineluctably to majority rule. Yet once it had dawned upon them that more than good manners would be required for majority rule to be achieved, their subsequent resort to arms forced a realization that vastly different organizational forms, strategies, and tactics of struggle would become necessary. Above all, such a transformation would require the formation of an armed wing of the nationalist movement and the articulation of political and military struggles (implying the need for military hierarchy, discipline, and security, thereby raising problems around the potential subordination of political openness and accountability to such influences). This might incur a legal banning of the organization by the oppressor regime; and it would require a particular form of heroism from activist individuals (who would be expected to evince willingness to lose life and limb, risk incarceration, leave home, abandon families, and become full-time revolutionaries). Furthermore, liberation struggle would require a higher level of both

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popular participation and accompanying class consciousness of diverse social strata (peasants, workers, and progressive bourgeoisie) recording their dedication to a radical agenda and 'class struggle', normally suggesting the supersession of the struggle for self-rule by a more far-reaching struggle for 'socialism'. Thus NLMs were widely projected as being more organizationally and theoretically advanced than the first wave of nationalist movements which achieved office during the initial phase of post-1945 decolonization. Whether or not they were more advanced in practice is a moot point. However, what is important is that legitimacy came to be conferred upon them by the Organization of African Unity (OAU) which formally recognized only those organizations which engaged in armed struggle as liberation movements.

There were two further dimensions which related particularly to the three countries which are of prime interest here, both relating to the ambiguous heritage of 'settler colonialism'. First, there was an ambiguity around 'race' and citizenship. It was easy enough to depict 'white settlers' as the principal beneficiaries of 'white domination'. Yet what constituted a 'settler'? Was it someone who themselves had just recently 'settled' upon Africa as their home? If so, what about those whites whose forbears had 'settled' in their countries of residence two, three or even more generations ago, and who had known no other 'home' but Africa? Why was a third- or fourth-generation white resident of Zimbabwe, Namibia or South Africa any more a 'settler' than an African who had recently migrated to one of these countries, or who sprung from ancestors who had moved from other parts of the continent in earlier times? Why weren't all Africans (save those defined controversially or otherwise as 'indigenous inhabitants') also 'settlers'? Suffice it to say here that NLMs found themselves awkwardly situated with regard to the status of whites who viewed themselves as living at 'home' while at the same time they identified 'white settlers', whose power was embodied in racially exclusionary regimes, as manifestly 'the enemy' of political liberation. Not surprisingly, this awkward circumstance led to debate, confusion, and division. The dilemmas it presented could only be resolved by commitment to the notion of a conception of citizenship which was open to all, regardless of 'race', and which was founded upon notions of individual racial equality and democracy. 'White settler regimes' therefore referred to those governments which were founded upon the racial exclusion of Africans from power and opportunity by restriction of the franchise to whites, and therefore became a definition founded upon political rather than racial criteria. Even so, questions around whether 'white citizens' could also claim to be authentically 'African' were to linger on well into post-liberation era and were to retain political volatility.

The second ambiguity revolved around the developmental potentialities which settler colonialism had brought. White settlers had tended to migrate towards territories which seemed to offer a temperate climate along with wealth and opportunity in terms of mineral resources and/or apparent availability of fertile and productive land, and where they were granted advantageous access to such opportunity by colonial or already established settler governments. White settler benefits were then backed up by manifold structures of political and economic oppression, the overthrow of which became central to the mission of 'national liberation'. Yet alongside this goal came an uncomfortable recognition that settler capitalism had facilitated much higher levels of capi-

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talist development and industrialization than in non-settler territories in Africa. On the one hand, this was recognized as having promoted advanced levels of both class- and racial-consciousness amongst the oppressed, thereby supposedly granting a high level of vitality and historical potential to NLMs.[1] On the other, the economic legacy of settler colonialism also heightened expectations of the rewards of national liberation, not only amongst the adherents of NLMs but also in the wider network of international solidarity support which developed around them.

International solidarity was to prove crucial to all anti-colonial struggles but reached its apogee in the support given to the liberation struggles in southern Africa. Broadly, we can identify three overlapping streams. First, there was straightforward Anti-Colonialist support, drawn principally from countries which themselves had experienced colonialism, and which found its expression in Third Worldist or Pan-Africanist sentiment in bodies such as the United Nations and the OAU. Second, there was Moralistic support, whose origins lay in religious and liberal sentiment (dating back to the Anti-Slavery Movement) and which was intellectually and politically founded upon rejection of racism and acceptance of democracy and human rights. Third, there was support from socialist and specifically working-class organizations, although this was to be substantially compromised by differences between Social Democrats and Communists which went back to the great divide of 1917, and which were deeply complicated by the global polarizations of the Cold War.

All these streams of support carried their own aspirations for the nature of the societies which would develop with the overthrow of racial domination. Nonetheless, they all shared fulsome hopes for the governments which would follow national liberation in the countries of southern Africa. It was not only that by the last two decades of the 20th century there was already widespread disillusionment with the performances in power of 'ordinary' African post-nationalist regimes, and that the economic potential of former settler colonies was substantially greater than the run of impoverished postcolonial territories, or that their former racist governments were peculiarly nasty. It was rather that southern African NLMs were widely deemed to have special qualities, whether these related to ideological sophistication, representativeness of advanced class formation or simply commitment to high-minded principle. This found its apogee in the global idolatory which was to be accorded to the ANC and its iconic leader, Nelson Mandela, around South Africa's transition to democracy in 1994.

Perhaps the hopes vested in the southern African NLMs were always unrealistically extravagant; perhaps a degree of disillusion with their post-liberation performance as governments was inevitable, especially given their difficult economic inheritance (for the developmental potential of settler capitalism was always highly problematic). However, today the reality of NLMs as governments has given rise to widespread feelings of disappointment. This arises not only from their failure to live up to expectations; rather it is that NLMs as governments have come to be widely perceived as embodying alarming post-liberation pathologies. They have become authoritarian, intolerant, careless if not actively abusive of human rights, and ironically, often racist. Worse, they are also seen

[1] Kenneth Good (1976), 'Settler colonialism: Economic development and class formation', *Journal of Modern African Studies*, 14: 4, 597–620.

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as having become corrupt, consumptionist, classist and anti-developmental. While the Mugabe regime in Zimbabwe has become a parody of all that is bad about postcolonial governments, SWAPO and the ANC are too often for comfort depicted as embodying ZANU-PF-like tendencies.[2]

So what has gone so wrong? Broadly we can identify three explanations, rooted in overlapping perspectives on NLMs as governments. The first is the 'Exclusivist Nationalism' approach, which focuses upon how NLMs use their struggle heritage to claim the right to rule; the second approach identifies post-liberation pathology as expressed via 'party dominance'; and the third, following Frantz Fanon, depicts the post-liberation NLM as an instrument of an avaricious post-nationalist bourgeoisie.

All three approaches provide important insights. However, the argument here is that the reality is more complex than any one of these approaches allows, and consequently we need to supplement them by returning to an earlier literature upon political parties in postcolonial Africa. But first, let us outline the three approaches to NLMs which presently predominate.

Exclusive nationalism

Writers from different intellectual traditions stress the monopolistic tendencies within national liberation thought which challenge democratic ideals and the legitimacy of political difference. From this perspective, the liberation struggle was conceived by NLMs as revolving principally around 'self-determination' (or in the South African case, the overthrow of apartheid) more than it was about achieving democracy. This was far from illogical, for there was no democracy under colonialism. However, the problem was that for the NLMs, 'self-determination' and 'democracy' became conflated, whereas they were neither identical nor necessarily congruent.[3] In other words, struggle for self-determination was more about equality of *peoples* as 'nations' than it was about equality for *people* as individuals.[4] This conflation allowed for NLMs to adopt a perspective which was not dissimilar to that propounded by Francis Fukuyama in relation to a propounded global ideological triumph of liberal democracy over communism at the end of the Cold War, as 'the end of history'. In the NLMs' case, however, the implication was that once the liberation movement had vanquished colonialism, history would dictate that it should (or would) stay in power for ever. R.W. Johnson has expressed this well when he writes of NLMs as sharing a 'common theology' which dictates that:

> National liberation is both the just and historically necessary conclusion of the struggle between the people and the forces of racism and colonialism. This has two implications. First, the NLMs – whatever venial sins they commit – are the righteous.

[2] James Hamill and John Hoffman (2011), 'The African National Congress and the Zanuification debate', in John Daniel, Prishani Naidoo, Devan Pillay and Roger Southall (eds), *New South African Review 2: New Paths, Old Compromises?* Johannesburg: Wits University Press, 50–67.

[3] Henning Melber (2003), 'Limits to liberation: An introduction to Namibia's postcolonial political culture', in Henning Melber (ed.), *Re-examining Liberation in Namibia: Political Culture since Independence*, Uppsala: Nordic Africa Institute, 9–24.

[4] Roger Southall (2003), 'Democracy in southern Africa: Moving beyond a difficult legacy', *Review of African Political Economy*, 30: 96, 255–72.

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> They do not merely represent the masses but in a sense they are the masses, and as such they cannot really be wrong. Secondly, according to the theology, their coming to power represents the end of a process. No further group can succeed them for that would mean that the masses, the forces of righteousness, had been overthrown. That, in turn, could only mean that the forces of racism and colonialism, after sulking in defeat and biding their time, had regrouped and launched a counter-attack.[5]

This essentially totalitarian mindset had a number of consequences. First, it demanded a conception of the colonially oppressed 'people' or 'nation' as one. In the context of anti-colonial struggle, in which NLMs were trying to forge national consciousness against a background of colonial divide and rule of diverse ethnic groupings, it made sense for NLMs to stress the 'oneness' of the 'oppressed nation'. Yet this supposed that the NLMs indubitably represented the will of the people, or in Rousseauian terms, 'the general will' – whereas in practice it meant that diversity amongst the oppressed along lines of ethnicity, gender or historical development was denied or suppressed. A second outcome was that, because NLMs could claim the authority of history, they and their leaders were imbued with a particular legitimacy, and challenges to their rule were therefore morally and politically illegitimate. Dissent was translated into disloyalty to the nation, as internal democracy transmogrified into obeisance to an authoritarian leader. Then again, a third outcome was what Terence Ranger has called the construction of 'patriotic history'.[6] Christopher Saunders describes this approach as:

> Not really history at all, but myth and propaganda. It does not tell the truth about the past, but emphasizes selected aspects of the past to present a picture of a glorious, continuous revolutionary tradition. It rejects academic history writing as an attempt to complicate the story of the past, and, instead, attempts to impose a hegemonic view of the liberation struggle. This writing…is not concerned with the liberation struggle versus the colonial oppressors as one of right against wrong, for the rightfulness of the independence struggle against white minority rule is taken for granted. It stresses, instead, another divide, between those who led the fight and won and those who compromised and should therefore be denounced as unpatriotic and sell-outs.[7]

Where such a theology has guided NLMs once they are in power, then scholars have depicted 'liberation' as working *against* democracy.[8] Indeed, in so far as national liberation has been based upon the gaining of national independence (or racial equality in South Africa) without having been linked to a project of fundamental social and economic transformation, it is seen as having 'exhausted' its progressive historical potential.[9] Worse still, such a constrained

[5] R.W. Johnson (2001), 'The final struggle is to stay in power', *Focus*, 25. Johannesburg: Helen Suzman Foundation.

[6] Terence Ranger (2003), 'Nationalist historiography, patriotic history, and the history of the nation: The struggle over the past in Zimbabwe', *Journal of Southern African Studies*, 30: 2, 215–34.

[7] Christopher Saunders (2003), 'History and the armed struggle: From anti-colonial propaganda to "patriotic history"?' in Melber (ed.), op. cit., 13–28.

[8] John Saul (1997), 'Liberal democracy vs. popular democracy in sub-Saharan Africa', *Review of African Political Economy*, 24: 73, 339–52.

[9] Samir Amin (1990), 'The social movements in the periphery: An end to liberation?' in Samir Amin, Giovanni Arrighi, Andre Gunder Frank and Immanuel Wallerstein (eds), *Transforming the Revolution: Social Movements and the World System*, New York: Monthly Review Press, 96–138.

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version of national liberation is depicted as positively reactionary, for as Abrahamsen has pointed out, a transformation of the structures of domination of the predecessor colonial state 'requires a parallel and profound change of their epistemological and psychological underpinnings and effects'.[10]

The Exclusive Nationalism approach clearly has much going for it, for it offers an essentially dialectical understanding of how and why victorious liberation movements can turn into regimes which are as oppressive as those they have replaced. Yet it is ultimately static, for while offering valuable critique of the political culture of NLMs, it tends to overlook processes of change which take place within them as time progresses – whether this be through death or ageing of the 'struggle generation' and the rise through the ranks of younger cadres, or through challenge to existing power-holders. In this, it shares failings akin to the second perspective, that of 'party dominance'.

The dominant party approach

The dominant party approach has been developed theoretically largely in relation to the ANC, although as we shall see, much of its thrust has been pursued in analysis of the political dominance of SWAPO, if rather less so in the case of ZANU-PF. But let us start with its South African foundation, which lies in the ANC's overwhelming electoral majority and its apparent invincibility at the polls.

By far the strongest argument for what some construe as the ANC's presently unassailable electoral dominance has been made by Susan Booysen, who demonstrates how the ANC-in-government uses its liberationist electoral appeal in combination with other 'repertoires of engagement' to regenerate its 'hegemonic power'.[11] Although she sees the ANC as faced by accumulating challenges, she projects a vision in which it will retain its hold on power for the foreseeable future. However, because she eschews explicit use of the 'party dominance' framework it is more informative to turn to the analyses of Hermann Giliomee and Charles Simkins, together with various associates.

Giliomee and Simkins define dominant parties as those which establish electoral dominance for a prolonged period and enjoy domination in the formation of governments and in determining the public agenda.[12] They argue that there is an inherent tension between dominant party rule and democracy, for whereas party dominance can lead to competitive democracy (as in, say Sweden), it can also lead to facade democracy and authoritarianism (as in Nazi Germany). However, in contrast to the Scandinavian precedent, they assert that dominant parties in semi-industrialised countries are far more likely to abuse their power, for their control over the state is more fragile and they have difficulty in establishing autonomy from capitalist interests. This leads to the following assertions about ANC-dominant party rule:

[10] Rita Abrahamsen (2003), 'African studies and the postcolonial challenge', *African Affairs*, 102: 407, 189–210.

[11] Susan Booysen (2011), *The African National Congress and the Regeneration of Political Power*, Johannesburg: Wits University Press, xvi.

[12] Hermann Giliomee and Charles Simkins (eds), (1999), *The Awkward Embrace: One Party Domination and Democracy*, Cape Town: Tafelberg.

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First, elections take on the character of a 'racial census', with the overwhelming black majority of the electorate regularly pledging their support to the ANC.

Second, although the transitional 1994 constitution provided for a distribution of power between the national state and nine provinces, the ANC has pursued a goal of greater centralization.

Third, whereas both the 1994 and 1996 constitutions (the latter drawn up by the first democratically elected parliament acting as a Constituent Assembly) insist upon the neutrality of public service, the ANC has subverted the independence of the state machinery, notably through the practice of the 'deployment' of party loyalists to public positions. This blurring of party and state has undermined the separation of powers and has marginalized parliament.

Fourth, the ANC has delegitimized opposition by asserting a crude majoritarianism which results in the alienation of minorities. This often takes an explicitly racial character, with opponents of the party accused of promoting white interests.

Finally, the ANC has adopted the principles of democratic centralism (borrowed from the Communist Party of the Soviet Union) and has utilized this to curb internal dissent.[13]

The thrust of the dominant party thesis is thus that the ANC has rendered itself largely unaccountable, and despite its regular return to power following free elections, constitutes a threat to the democracy. Prolonged concentration of power leads to abuse, and only the presence of opposition parties as viable alternative governments will ensure the success of democracy.

Undoubtedly, the dominant party thesis has proved a powerful tool for analyzing the ANC in power. Nonetheless, the thesis has lent itself to gross exaggeration, notably in its suggestion of the ANC's quasi-totalitarianism and its capacity to exert its authority over state and society (where it faces limits ranging from decisions of the Constitutional Court through to protests by its own constituency over 'failures of delivery'). In contrast, critics of the dominant party thesis have stressed that it was the ANC which was the harbinger of democracy in South Africa; it was the force which primarily responsible for the human rights-based nature of the constitution; and it continues to secure its electoral dominance because it retains the organizational capacity to mobilize popular support at election time. Thus, whilst a 'weak' notion of the ANC as a dominant party can be useful (for the fact of the ANC's electoral dominance and its domination of most state arenas is indisputable),[14] application of a tidy thesis tends to run up against the messiness of South African reality.

Not least of the limitations of the dominant party thesis is its inability to address the issue of change. Its assumption of the ANC's quasi-totalitarianism, notably in the form of its 'democratic centralism', implies a party which is unambiguously controlled from above by an elite. Yet manifestly this does not describe the ANC of today. This was demonstrated dramatically by the defeat of Thabo Mbeki when he ran for a third term as President of the ANC at the

[13] Hermann Giliomee, John Myburgh and Lawrence Schlemmer (2001), 'Dominant party rule, opposition politics and minorities in South Africa', in Roger Southall (ed.), *Opposition and Democracy in South Africa*, London: Frank Cass, 161–82.

[14] Roger Southall (2001), 'Conclusion: Emergent perspectives on opposition in South Africa', in Southall (ed.), op. cit., 275–84.

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latter's 52nd National Conference at Polokwane in December 2007, and his subsequent ousting from the state presidency in September 2008. There are a variety of interpretations of the 'meaning' of Polokwane.[15] However, what is clear is that the incumbent elites within the party proved unable to meet the challenge posed by a candidate who was significantly supported by popular forces 'from below'. So much, we might say, for the salience of 'democratic centralism'!

Yet a further problem is that, while the ANC continues to claim genuine popular majorities at successive elections, its electoral dominance is increasingly under threat, as the loyalty of its mass constituency begins to crumble and as voters become rather more pragmatic.[16] Indeed, it is apposite to note that Raymond Suttner, a long-time activist within the liberation struggle, today sees danger to constitutional democracy in the erosion of ANC dominance, with its post-Mbeki internal divisions encouraging a resort to political intolerance and what he terms the 'formulaic thinking' of an anti-pluralist, authoritarian, and centralist 'NLM model'.[17]

There are many aspects of the Namibian situation which lend themselves to analysis through the lenses of 'party dominance', for SWAPO combines popular support, registered at regular elections, with a marked shift towards authoritarianism.[18] However, the limits to the utility of the 'dominant party' approach are illustrated by the Zimbabwean case. Zimbabwe has experienced successive multi-party elections since independence, yet these have been subject to wide-ranging manipulation by the regime to produce victories for ZANU-PF, which all too graphically indicate that it does not consider its hold on power as ultimately subject to popular choice. At root, the notion of 'party dominance' rests upon an acceptance of 'democracy'. In other words, for all that popularly elected political parties may seek to strengthen their hold on power through institutional and other means, they ultimately concede the validity of results at the ballot box, and if they lose their popular hegemony as recorded by elections, they stand down from office.

In short, the 'dominant party' thesis may well illuminate important dimensions of both the ANC and SWAPO as ruling parties, but its basis in electoral performance limits its utility. Indeed, precisely because it points to how dominant parties may resort to electoral abuse in order to reproduce successive electoral powers, it points to possession and use of state power as the major factor requiring analysis – not least in the case of NLMs whose theology prescribes their historic right to rule. This leads us to examine the approach of those following in the footsteps of Frantz Fanon, who focus upon how the colonial experience has distorted the paths pursued by nationalist movements which have succeeded to power.

[15] Roger Southall (2009), 'Understanding the "Zuma tsunami"', *Review of African Political Economy*, 121: 317–33.

[16] Anthony Butler (2009), Considerations on the erosion of one-party dominance', *Representation: Journal of Representative Democracy*, 45: 2, 159–72.

[17] Raymond Suttner (2009), 'The challenges to African National Congress dominance', *Representation: Journal of Representative Democracy*, 45: 2, 173–92.

[18] Henning Melber (2011), 'SWAPO is the nation, and the nation is SWAPO: Government and opposition in a dominant party state – the case of Namibia', in Katharina Hulterström, Amin Kamete and Henning Melber, *Political Opposition in African Countries: The Cases of Kenya, Namibia, Zambia and Zimbabwe*, Uppsala: Nordic Africa Institute, 61–83.

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Fanon in southern Africa

'The Revolution Betrayed' is almost as old an idea as that of social revolution itself, for human history offers a litany of examples of frustrated revolutionary hopes. In southern Africa, the liberation struggles invoked particularly high levels of popular participation. Notions of 'people's war', founded upon liberation movements' claimed or genuine politicization of the masses, peasantry and proletariat, promoted widespread revolutionary hopes, and regularly conflated the struggles against white supremacy, colonialism, and apartheid into struggles for socialism.[19] Subsequently, too, the legacy of massive popular resistance to oppression encouraged hopes that bonds between the liberation movements and 'the people' would remain strong and provide a foundation for the construction of 'popular democracy' rather than mere liberal democracy. Generally, however, such hopes have been disappointed, for in one liberated country after another, rather than socialism, capitalism continues to reign, embraced by liberation movements whose political character is often disturbingly authoritarian. In such circumstances, it is scarcely surprising that disillusion abounds. Nor is it surprising that those disappointed with liberation struggle outcomes should turn to Frantz Fanon for explanation.

According to Fanon, the national bourgeoisie that takes power at the end of colonialism is an underdeveloped class, small in number, lacking economic power and primarily located in service rather than directly productive occupations. Lacking intellectual resources, it seeks little more than to step into the shoes of departing colonials, seeking to transfer into its own hands their resources through strategies of nationalization and Africanization. Once in control of key posts, it will insist that all big foreign companies should deal with it directly, whether they simply want to keep their connections with the country or to open it up. Thus 'the national middle class discovers its historic mission: that of intermediary'.[20] Although often prepared to resort to a (defensive) racism against a cynical Western bourgeoisie, the national bourgeoisie nonetheless seeks to emulate the latter's lifestyle and ultimately, to identify with it. It engages in 'scandalous enrichment' and 'immoderate money making', and plunges into 'the mire of corruption and pleasure'.[21] In such circumstances, 'the economic channels of the young state sink back inevitably into neo-colonialist lines', dependent upon external capital and handouts.[22]

It is scarcely surprising that Fanon's characterization of the postcolonial situation should spread to post-liberation southern Africa. An illustration is the analysis provided by John Saul in a bitterly unhappy essay where he takes as his cue the statement offered by George Dangerfield,[23] concerning the fate of the

[19] For an overview of the envisaged socialist promise, see John Saul (1994), 'The Southern African revolution', in John Saul (ed.), *Recolonization and Resistance: Southern Africa in the 1990s*, Trenton: Africa World Press, 1–34.

[20] Frantz Fanon (1974), *The Wretched of the Earth*, London: Penguin, 122.

[21] Ibid., 134–35.

[22] Ibid., 134.

[23] George Dangerfield (1997), *The Strange Death of Liberal England*, Stanford CA: Stanford University Press.

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British Liberals following their triumph at the polls at the end of the First World War: they emerged from the fray 'flushed with one of the greatest victories of all time, yet from that victory they never recovered'. Something similar, Saul suggests, can be said of FRELIMO in Mozambique,[24] the MPLA in Angola,[25] SWAPO, ZANU-PF, and the ANC. Although all still in power, they have come to preside over the death of the promise that they were once thought to epitomize. The importance of their victories (over colonialism, racism, and apartheid) should never be minimized, yet the socialist hopes that they embodied have succumbed to political degeneration. In Mozambique, corruption and the pursuit of individual profit have undermined the legitimacy of FRELIMO party leaders, while the election of Guebeza – 'holder of an expansive business network'[26] – as President in 2002 signalled commitment to a neo-liberal agenda. Much the same has happened in Angola where the liberation struggle descended into a bloody war between the MPLA and UNITA,[27] which was little more than a raw struggle between rival elites for oil and diamonds. It is the same story in both Namibia, where the party elite lives in luxury disregarding the abject poverty of the majority, and Zimbabwe, where Mugabe's ZANU-PF has engaged in vicious repression of the opposition Movement for Democratic Change (MDC). However, it is South Africa which provides the most disappointing case of 'false decolonization', for by enthusiastically embracing capitalism, the ANC has 'squandered an opportunity of world historic proportions'.[28] Yet why, asks Saul, has this happened to NLMs which had promised so much?

Saul acknowledges that NLMs have been pressured by the World Bank, IMF, and Western governments to join the global capitalist game. But the implication is that regional leaders have too easily accepted the apparent inevitability of capitalism as being the only strategy capable of providing for development. Thus the ANC government may have opted for a reformist version of capitalism hoping that it would provide sufficient surplus to allow social policies capable of alleviating social inequality. However, while this option might to a limited extent be possible in South Africa, it is much less plausible in neighbouring countries which are located even more at the periphery of global capitalism. In these circumstances, it is scarcely to be wondered if NLMs have opted for self-enrichment. Thus, Saul ends up with an explicitly Fanonesque explanation involving the selling out of the revolution by new elites, their comfortable adjustment to neo-colonialism, the diversion of a revolutionary class consciousness amongst the majority into racial consciousness, and the adoption of market values and consumerism. In so doing he is by no means alone. Take, for instance, the views of Henning Melber with regard to Namibia:

> More than forty years ago Frantz Fanon had already expressed in his revolutionary manifesto, *The Wretched of the Earth*, disgust for the emerging new elites he witnessed in independent (West) African countries…he demonstrated that the

[24] Front for the Liberation of Mozambique.
[25] People's Movement for the Liberation of Angola.
[26] John Saul (2008), *Decolonization and Empire: Contesting the Rhetoric and Reality of Resubordination in Southern Africa and Beyond*, Johannesburg: Wits University Press, 156.
[27] National Union for the Total Independence of Angola.
[28] Saul (2008), op. cit., 164.

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> psuedo-revolutionary rhetoric of the representatives of new state power was a misleading façade. His scathing attacks on a new hegemonic nationalist elite project, with its particular blend of populist nation-building, questioned the extent of meaningful social change for the majority of the previously underprivileged colonized population in the wake of decolonization. In contrast to the settler colonialism endured for so many decades under the apartheid regime, the sovereign Republic of Namibia in its present state has, despite many short-comings, much to offer most of its people. But it also fails to meet some of the more substantive and essential original ideals, ambitions and aims that were once articulated by the same social forces and their leaders who now exercise political power.[29]

All this can be illuminating, and importantly, it locates the one-time liberationist bourgeoisie within a context of global capitalism, imperialism, and dependence. However, ultimately Fanonism tends to substitute 'class' for 'party', proposing that the liberation movements have become nothing more than the instruments of the postcolonial bourgeoisie for political domination and economic accumulation. Further, the uniformity of Fanonism's portrayal of the NLMs in power minimizes important realities: the existence within them of continuing factionalism, of debates between nationalist and socialist tendencies, between populists and political progressives, and contested as well as collaborative relationships with foreign and domestic capital.

Is there a mode of explanation which allows for all this, while simultaneously acknowledging that characteristics of NLMs may change over time? It is suggested here that there is, located in the idea of 'the party machine'.

NLMs as party machines

In 1996, Artur Carlos Maurício Pestana (under his nom de guerre, Pepetela) published a novel based on his experiences in 1971 in the guerrilla war waged by the MPLA in the rainforests of Angola's Cabinda province. The book displays a remarkable insight into the complexity of social transformation subsequent to armed resistance to colonial occupation. In a revealing dialogue, the commander of the guerrilla unit, 'Fearless', proclaims his fears and ideals to the unit's political commissar, 'New World', for whom he ultimately sacrifices his life in battle:

> We don't share the same ideals…You are the machine type, one of those who are going to set up the unique, all-powerful Party in Angola. I am the type who could never belong to the machine…One day, in Angola, there will no longer be any need for rigid machines, and that is my aim…what I want you to understand, is that the revolution we are making is half the revolution I want. But it is the possible. I know my limits and the country's limits. My role is to contribute to this half-revolution…I am, in your terminology, adventurist. I should like the discipline of war to be established in terms of man and not the political objective. My guerrillas are not a group of men deployed to destroy the enemy, but a gathering of different, individual beings, each with his subjective reasons to struggle and who, moreover, behave as such…I am happy when I see a young man decide to build himself a personality, even if politically that signifies individualism…I

[29] Melber (2003), op. cit., 9–25.

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> cannot manipulate men, I respect them too much as individuals. For that reason, I cannot belong to a machine.[30]

Fearless clearly had enough of the early Marx in him to recognize the dangers inherent in revolutionaries changing themselves into apparatchiks, dreary hacks who would sacrifice their ideals to every whim of an all-powerful party in pursuit of safety, personal advantage, and a career. For Pestana, reality was dialectical: the NLM as the vehicle of collective freedom would turn into a 'machine' whose inherent characteristic was to subordinate individualism and individual freedoms.

Pestana was not alone in foreseeing the dangers represented by the NLMs' transformation into political machines. Even before any of the regional NLMs took power, Rick Turner, the activist academic (eventually assassinated by apartheid security forces) was bold enough to discuss the potential threat to democracy their victory might represent:

> The political party as mediator between the individual and government tends to take on the characteristics of the system itself, the 'party machine' dominates the membership and the rank and file become increasingly divorced from policy making…The political arena becomes polarised between an atomised mass and a number of small groups trying to manipulate the mass in order to get political jobs. The result of this is to move the source of power in society out of the political arena and into the control of functional power groups.[31]

The analyses of Pestana and Turner were deeply rooted in Marxist theorizing, yet ironically conventional political science had already most clearly depicted the rise of the party machine in postcolonial Africa, as notably examined in Aristide Zolberg's classic study of the trajectories of the victorious nationalist parties in Ghana, Senegal, Mali, and Ivory Coast.[32]

In all four states which Zolberg examined, the handover of power to nationalists saw the emergence of parties to which he ascribes the label 'dominant'. He describes how it was widely assumed that this outcome was the result of the victorious parties' greater political capacities relative to their rivals. Hence contrasts were drawn between 'mass' and 'cadre' parties, and more tendentiously, 'revolutionary centralizing' and 'pragmatic pluralist' parties, with the former categories generally being described as more vital, dynamic, and inclusive. Yet, such a contrast was to prove misleading, for in practice both types of parties tended to take upon themselves the supposed qualities of the other. Even where successful (usually 'mass') nationalist parties went on to establish themselves as single parties, it was regularly found that their resemblance to parties of the European left (upon which many had modelled themselves) was no more than superficial.

Zolberg's thrust proceeded as follows. The victorious nationalist parties triumphed following an initial spurt of mobilization which captured the spirit of post-Second World War popular aspiration. Although winning pre-

[30] Pepetela (1996), *Mayombe*, London: Heinemann, 197. I am grateful to Henning Melber for this reference.

[31] Richard Turner (1971), 'The relevance of contemporary radical thought', in Peter Randall (ed.), *Directions of Change in South African Politics*, Johannesburg: Spro-Cas, 81.

[32] Aristide Zolberg (1966), *Creating Political Order: The Party-States of West Africa*, Chicago: Rand McNally Publishing Company.

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independence elections, the popular support such parties received was limited, for rates of electoral registration were often quite low, and minority parties often took a substantial slice of the vote. Subsequently, after assuming office, nationalist parties benefited from gaining access to well-paid jobs, state resources and control over national budgets, all of which allowed them to determine who would obtain benefits and where they should be located. Thereafter, popular participation expanded via enlargement of electorates, while at the same time, the authority of parliaments and African executives was increased. As a result, nationalist parties faced two contrary trends: on the one hand, they benefited from a bandwagon effect, as numerous individuals identified with them as winners; on the other, they encountered the risk of fragmentation, for competition for control of the new institutions intensified as new political entrepreneurs entered the game. Very often, political entrepreneurship entailed an appeal to primordial loyalties, usually in the form of ethnic affinities. This in turn posed the threat that the nationalist movements would suffer from a 'reverse bandwagon' effect and relapse into ethnicity or regionalism. In response, the parties sought to increase control from the centre, often accompanied by their ideological radicalization. Furthermore, because their organizational capacity was indeed superior to that of their rivals, they were enabled to consolidate their political dominance, in some cases installing themselves as single parties with a revolutionary ideology: to proclaim the necessity of national unity under the aegis of the ruling party itself. This was succinctly put in Nkrumah's famous slogan: 'The CPP is Ghana and Ghana is the CPP.'[33] 'National unity' was then obtained by suppression of the opposition and electoral manipulation.

Such a process described so-called 'revolutionary mobilizing' regimes. Although such parties aspired to mobilize the entire nation, their capacity to do so rarely extended beyond occasional electioneering; participant members were relatively few; support had both regional and ethnic dimensions; 'they had a large head in the capital but fairly rudimentary limbs'; and although speaking the language of democratic centralism, internal structures of accountability and control only functioned intermittently. Indeed, Zolberg cites David Apter, one of the earliest observers of the CPP in Ghana, as referring to it as 'a Tammany type machine with a nationalist ideology',[34] a reference to the Democratic Party political machine that controlled Manhattan from 1854 to 1932 through strong-arm tactics, patronage, and corruption.

Single-partyism led on to the 'party state', the merger of government and party. Nationalist leaders had two principal instruments of rule: the party and the state bureaucracy. The former, supposedly, was mass based, united and disciplined, yet was often little more than 'a loose movement which naturally incorporated the characteristics of the society in which it grew'.[35] The government, in contrast, was alien, and until recently run by Europeans according to strange bureaucratic norms. Nonetheless, it was the most concrete expression of central authority available. Given a huge shortage of educated personnel within the party, many of the most capable loyalists were appointed to govern-

[33] The Convention People's Party.

[34] Zolberg, op. cit., 22, citing David Apter (1955) *The Gold Coast in Transition*, Princeton: Princeton University Press, 202.

[35] Ibid., 123.

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ment, depriving the party itself of their skills. Meanwhile, a deep-seated suspicion of government bureaucrats led to attempts to incorporate civil servants into the party. The outcome was predictable: the coherence of the party machinery declined, matched by the decline in efficiency of the civil service. Simultaneously, an accompanying trend towards centralization of authority in the hands of the President led to his reliance upon lieutenants, some of whom owed their position to the party and others of whom had risen through the bureaucracy, but all of whom, ultimately, owed their loyalty and legitimacy to their 'chief'. Because this hybrid pattern extended downwards throughout the party-government complex, the lines of authority became confused. The outcome was contestation between party and state; the centre and the periphery; in-groups and out-groups; and indeed between the President and his lieutenants, with the awkward mix becoming dependent upon personal and political loyalties.

The study of political parties in Africa has by now moved well beyond Zolberg's schema. Nonetheless, there is still considerable value to be drawn from his analysis.

First, the analysis of the party-state, with its implications of simultaneous strength (resting upon institutional foundations) and fragility (its incorporation of the cleavages inherent in 'underdeveloped' societies), is suggestive of strong parallels in southern Africa, notably the shift from liberation movements to institutionalized hegemony, albeit with such dominance rendered incomplete by the ruling party's own heterogeneity, internal contestations, and intermittent internal democracy.

Second, a return to Zolberg (and other students of the early nationalist parties) has the virtue of taking political parties seriously. As any perusal of those writings demonstrates, the nationalist parties were faced by a multiplicity of challenges, the meeting of which involved them in a diversity of roles: what Tordoff (amongst others) refers to as their integrative, legitimizing, policy, mobilization, reconciliation, patronage, and political communication functions.[36] Doubtless a great deal of such analysis underplayed the emergence of new class structures, the transformation of ruling parties into agencies of class rule, and the contradictions involved in countries where radical parties, themselves subject to such tendencies, were simultaneously committed to socialist transformation. Nonetheless, at the time, experiments in one-party democracy and African socialism were taken seriously by radical analysts, most notably those concerned with the attempt to promote socialism in Tanzania.[37] While in a later era Saul and others are correct in emphasizing the formidable battery of means which Western capitalism utilized to discipline African countries, that does not justify a dismissive approach to former NLMs which, like it or not, are performing (with varying success) the political roles of their predecessors. The question should rather be: how are they performing, why, and in whose interest?

Third, there is much to be said in returning to Zolberg's notion of the nationalist (or liberation) movement as transforming into a party machine. This, we suggest, allows for:

[36] William Tordoff (2010), *Government and Politics in Africa*, London: Palgrave Macmillan.

[37] Lionel Cliffe and John Saul (eds), (1972), *Socialism in Tanzania: An Interdisciplinary Reader. Vol. 1. Politics*, Nairobi: East African Publishing House.

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(i) Examination of the capacities of NLMs for undertaking those various *functions of the political party*. In particular, it invites analysis of the functioning of the NLMs' structures in terms of control from above; participation from below; and 'official' versus 'unofficial' lines of authority. It also requires an understanding of how capacities to mobilize are underpinned by the raising and allocation of resources (the issue of party funding).
(ii) Analysis of *the role of the party in providing avenues of recruitment, advancement, and social class formation*. This allows for the possibility that the nature of the party may change over time, perhaps from being a vehicle of liberation to one which is an instrument of political control and economic accumulation by an elite.
(iii) A focus upon the party as a *machine for the allocation of positions, privileges, resources, and contracts.* Perhaps this does signify something of a return to the earlier doctrines of US political science, of notions of politics as the allocation of values, of who gets what, why and when, yet it also interlocks with Fanonist notions of the party as an instrument of class domination. Critically, because the party is operating within a context of resource scarcity, it demands analysis of party relations with the state and with capital, for it is they which constitute the primary founts of resources.
(iv) Finally, *resource scarcity implies intra-party competition between 'ins' and 'outs'; between different components of the coalition which a ruling party represents; and between different segments of the political elite*. This points to the necessity of the identification of groups linked together by bonds of interest (not exclusive of ideology) and their location within the party-state across level, class, and ethnicity.

By focusing upon the NLMs of Namibia, South Africa, and Zimbabwe as 'party machines' it is possible to appropriate the utilities of all existing approaches to liberation movement rule. In particular, the intention here will be to examine the *differences* between the liberation movements as they have developed, as much as the *similarities* between them, given the diversity of their colonial heritages and postcolonial global locations. But as Pestana and Turner suggest, once the purpose of the machine translates into the objective of aggrandizement, it is likely to launch upon a process of political, social, and ideological decline. The argument of this book is that this is the challenge facing the NLMs in southern Africa. However, before that can be pursued, it is necessary to examine their origins and development in their struggles against settler colonialism.

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